

Key facts

Globally, there are more than 700 million people aged 65 years and over. **More than one out of three older people** lives in the Western Pacific Region. The aged population is expected to double by 2050 in the Region and globally.

The Western Pacific Region is experiencing **unprecedented speed and depth of ageing**. This has significant social implications but also offers many potential opportunities for individuals and society.

Preparing for changing population demographics takes time, but experiences from countries in the Region suggest that **early action can turn challenges into opportunities**.

The Western Pacific Region has **one of the largest and fastest-growing older populations in the world**. In many of the Region's younger countries, the pace of ageing is accelerating. Countries such as Australia and New Zealand took over 60 years to make the transition from an ageing population (more than 7% over 65) to an aged population (more than 14% over 65). In comparison, younger countries and areas such as Brunei Darussalam, French Polynesia and Viet Nam are expected to make this transition in less than 20 years.

Population ageing has significant implications for society. These include an increased burden of noncommunicable diseases and growing diversity in older people's functional ability. Supporting healthy ageing requires **health system transformation** to address medical conditions and create beneficial social environments **throughout people's lives**. Further, **community services and supports that are tailored to individual needs** will enable more older adults to actively participate in society. To fully realize these opportunities, **a change in narrative** is needed. Rather than viewing older people as social burdens, focus should be shifted to the many valuable contributions they can make to society when supported and encouraged to do so.

Preparing for population ageing requires a long-term, whole-of-society change.

A shift in mindset is needed, as well as investment, commitment and coordination across all sectors of society. These changes take time. However, experiences from aged countries suggest that early investments can yield significant health and economic returns by mitigating potential increases in health-care costs and enabling more older people to participate in and contribute to society.

WHO response

With continued improvements in life expectancy and declining birth rates in the Region, all countries and areas will continue to see a growing ageing population. In preparation for this demographic shift, all Member States must take action now.

To support Member States to prepare for population ageing, **WHO has developed the Regional Action Plan on Healthy Ageing** in consultation with experts, partners and other stakeholders in the Region. The Regional Action Plan outlines a lifelong, multisectoral approach to promoting healthier older adults who actively participate in and contribute to society. The plan reflects lessons learnt from countries and areas in the Region.

WHO will support Member States to operationalize the Regional Action Plan by **providing technical support to develop national guidelines, strategies and tools**. WHO will also monitor and provide updates on the progress of implementing the Plan.

Further, WHO plays an important role in compiling data, research and case studies. WHO will work with Member States to **share knowledge and facilitate dialogue about experiences, lessons learnt and best practices**.



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